ECS / HOC • COMPLETE STUDY GUIDE

English Communication Skills

Exam Pattern | Grammar | Vocabulary | Reading | Writing

Theory notes, practice questions, answers and solved examples

Grammar **Vocabulary** **Reading** **Writing**

Total exam time: 1 hour 50 minutes • Grammar & Vocabulary 25 min • Reading 35 min • Writing 50 min

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1. Exam Pattern

ECS / HOC Exam – Complete Explanation (Paper Pattern)

Exam Format

- Exam mein mainly **3 sections** hote hain: **Grammar & Vocabulary, Reading,** aur **Writing**.
- Total Exam Time: **1 hour 50 minutes**.
- Exam mein approximately **50 questions** Grammar & Vocabulary se related hote hain.
- Baqi questions Reading aur Writing ko assess karte hain.

Part	Section	Time
Part 1	Grammar & Vocabulary	25 minutes
Part 2	Reading	35 minutes
Part 3	Writing	50 minutes
Total	All sections	1 hour 50 minutes

Part 1 – Grammar & Vocabulary | 25 Minutes

Grammar

Grammar mein different levels test kiye jate hain. Total **25 questions** hotay hain:

- A1–A2
- B1–B2
- C1

IMPORTANT Majority MCQs A1–A2 aur B1–B2 levels se hote hain. C1 level se normally sirf 2–3 MCQs hote hain. C1 questions comparatively thora difficult hote hain. Overall grammar ka kaafi portion woh hota hai jo aap FSC level par already study kar chuke hote hain.

Vocabulary

Vocabulary mein different types ke questions aa sakte hain. Total **25 questions** hotay hain:

- Word Matching
- Word Definition
- Word Usage
- Word Pairs / Combinations

Is liye vocabulary mein sirf words ke meanings nahi, balkay unka **correct usage aur combination** bhi prepare karna important hai.

Part 2 – Reading | 35 Minutes

Reading Section: **4 Parts**

1. Sentence Comprehension

- Aapko 5 sentences diye jayenge.
- Har sentence mein ek word missing hoga.
- Aapko 3 options mein se appropriate word select karna hoga.

Is mein sentence ka meaning aur context samajhna important hai.

2. Text Cohesion

- Is part mein 2 questions honge.
- Har question mein 6 sentences hongi.
- Sentences wrong order mein di jayengi.
- First sentence already identify ki hui hogi.
- Aapko baqi sentences ko correct sequence mein arrange karna hoga.
- Is ka sirf ek correct solution hoga.

Yahan sentence ke beech logical connection aur sequence samajhna important hai.

3. Opinion Matching

- Is mein 4 short paragraphs honge.
- Har paragraph different person ki opinion represent karega.
- Saath mein 7 statements di jayengi.
- Aapko determine karna hoga ke kaunsi statement kis person's opinion se match karti hai.

Is ke liye paragraphs ko carefully read karna zaroori hai.

4. Long Text Comprehension

- Is section mein 7 paragraphs honge.
- Sab paragraphs same topic se related honge.
- Saath mein 8 headings di jayengi.
- 1 heading extra hogi jo kisi paragraph ke liye suitable nahi hogi.
- Aapko har paragraph ke liye appropriate heading select karni hogi.

Is mein main idea of each paragraph identify karna sab se important hai.

Part 3 – Writing | 50 Minutes

Writing section mein **4 parts** include hote hain:

- Word Level Writing
- Short Text Writing
- Three Written Responses to Questions
- Formal & Informal Writing

1. Formal Email

- Word limit: **120–150 words**.
- Koshish karein ke word limit ke andar hi writing complete ho.
- Aapka main concern/message clearly communicate hona chahiye.
- Formal email mein **contractions use nahi** karni chahiye.

Formal email ka tone professional aur clear hona chahiye.

2. Informal Email

- Word limit: **40–50 words**.
- Is mein bhi word limit exceed nahi karni.
- Writing ko short, clear aur relevant rakhein.

Exam Format – Writing Section (Pattern)

The Writing section lasts approximately **50 minutes**. It includes four task types. The first three require short, clear responses; the final task involves formal and informal emails.

Task	What you do
1. Word Level Writing	Aap club, course ya activity ke members ke 5 messages ka mukhtasar jawab dete hain. Har jawab seedha message ka jawab dena chahiye. Is kaam mein lambe paragraphs ki zaroorat nahi hoti.
2. Short Text Writing	Aap kisi di gayi situation ke liye taqreeban 20–30 lafzon ka ek chhota text likhte hain. Apna jawab relevant rakhein aur sahi grammar, spelling aur punctuation istemal karein.
3. Three Written Responses to Questions	Aap 3 alag alag sawal ka jawab dete hain, aksar online ya social-network ke context mein. Har sawal ka saaf jawab dein aur topic par qayam rahein.
4. Formal & Informal Writing	You write emails using the appropriate tone. A formal email is polite and professional; an informal email is friendly and conversational. Follow the word limit stated in the task.

Remember: Read each prompt carefully, answer what is asked, and check grammar, spelling, and punctuation.

2. Grammar

Theory notes with easy explanations, examples and practice MCQs

Grammar helps us make clear and correct sentences. Each topic includes an easy explanation, examples, and short practice questions.

1. Prepositions

Definition & Explanation

A preposition shows the relationship between a noun or pronoun and another word. It often tells us about place, time, direction, or position.

Examples

- The book is on the table.
- We meet at 9 a.m.
- She walked into the room.

Practice MCQs

1. The class starts ___ 9 a.m.

A. in B. at C. on

Answer: B. Use *at* for a specific time.

2. The cat is hiding ___ the bed.

A. under B. during C. towards

Answer: A. *Under* shows position.

3. He lives ___ Karachi.

A. at B. in C. on

Answer: B. Use *in* with a city.

2. Adverbs

Definition & Explanation

An adverb gives more information about a verb, adjective, or another adverb. It may tell us how, when, where, or how often something happens.

Examples

- She speaks clearly.
- He arrived yesterday.
- The children played outside.

Practice MCQs

1. She completed the work ___.
A. careful B. carefully C. care
Answer: B. *Carefully* describes how she worked.

2. We will leave ___.
A. soon B. soft C. slow
Answer: A. *Soon* tells us when.

3. He ___ visits his grandparents.
A. regular B. regularly C. regularity
Answer: B. *Regularly* tells us how often.

3. Tenses

Definition & Explanation

Tense shows when an action happens: in the present, past, or future. A tense may describe a regular action, an action in progress, or a completed action.

Examples

- Present: I study every day.
- Past: I studied yesterday.
- Future: I will study tomorrow.
- Present continuous: She is reading now.

Practice MCQs

1. Ali ___ to college every day.
A. go B. goes C. went
Answer: B. Present simple: use *goes* with he/she/it.

2. They ___ a film last night.
A. watch B. watched C. will watch
Answer: B. *Last night* signals the past.

3. I ___ you tomorrow.
A. called B. call yesterday C. will call
Answer: C. *Tomorrow* signals the future.

4. She ___ dinner right now.
A. cooks B. cooked C. is cooking
Answer: C. Use present continuous for an action happening now.

5. We have ___ our homework.
A. finish B. finished C. finishing
Answer: B. Present perfect uses have/has + past participle.

4. Modal Verbs

Definition & Explanation

Modal verbs are helping verbs that express ability, permission, possibility, advice, or necessity. Common modals include can, could, may, might, must, should, and would.

Examples

- I can swim.
- You should rest.
- May I come in?

Practice MCQs

1. You ___ wear a seat belt. It is necessary.
A. might B. must C. would
Answer: B. *Must* expresses necessity.

2. ___ I borrow your pen, please?
A. May B. Must C. Should
Answer: A. *May* can ask permission.

3. You look tired. You ___ take a break.
A. should B. can't C. mustn't
Answer: A. *Should* gives advice.

5. Conditionals

Definition & Explanation

Conditional sentences connect a condition with a result. **First conditional:** a real future possibility. **Second conditional:** an unreal or unlikely situation. **Third conditional:** an imagined past situation.

Examples

- First: If it rains, we will stay home.
- Second: If I had time, I would travel.
- Third: If she had studied, she would have passed.

Practice MCQs

1. If you study, you ___ the test.
A. will pass B. would have passed C. passed
Answer: A. First conditional: if + present, will + verb.

2. If I ___ rich, I would help others.
A. am B. were C. will be
Answer: B. Second conditional commonly uses *were*.

3. If he had left earlier, he ___ the bus.
A. would catch B. will catch C. would have caught
Answer: C. Third conditional uses would have + past participle.

6. Connectors

Definition & Explanation

Connectors join words, phrases, or sentences. They show addition, contrast, reason, result, or sequence.

Examples

- I was tired, but I finished my work.
- Because it rained, we stayed inside.
- She studied; therefore, she passed.

Practice MCQs

1. I wanted to go, ___ I was ill.
A. because B. but C. therefore
Answer: B. *But* shows contrast.

2. It rained; ___, the match was cancelled.
A. therefore B. although C. meanwhile
Answer: A. *Therefore* shows a result.

3. She stayed home ___ she was unwell.
A. because B. however C. or
Answer: A. *Because* gives a reason.

7. Comparatives

Definition & Explanation

A comparative compares two people, places, or things. Short adjectives often take *-er*; longer adjectives often use *more*. Some forms are irregular, such as good → better.

Examples

- A train is faster than a bus.
- This book is more interesting than that one.
- Today is better than yesterday.

Practice MCQs

1. My bag is ___ than yours.
A. heavy B. heavier C. heaviest
Answer: B. Use *heavier* to compare two bags.

2. This task is ___ difficult than the last one.
A. more B. most C. much
Answer: A. Use *more* with many longer adjectives.

3. Sara is ___ at maths than Ali.
A. good B. better C. best
Answer: B. The comparative of *good* is *better*.

8. Gerunds and Infinitives

Definition & Explanation

A gerund is an *-ing* verb form used like a noun. An infinitive is usually *to* + base verb. Some verbs are followed by gerunds and others by infinitives.

Examples

- Swimming is good exercise.
- I enjoy reading.
- She wants to learn English.

Practice MCQs

1. I enjoy ___ novels.
A. to read B. reading C. read
Answer: B. *Enjoy* is followed by a gerund.

2. He hopes ___ a doctor.
A. becoming B. become C. to become
Answer: C. *Hope* is followed by an infinitive.

3. ___ every day improves your English.
A. Practise B. Practising C. To practising
Answer: B. A gerund can be the subject.

9. Active and Passive Voice

Definition & Explanation

In active voice, the subject performs the action. In passive voice, the subject receives the action. Passive forms use a form of *be* + past participle.

Examples

- Active: The chef cooked the meal.
- Passive: The meal was cooked by the chef.
- Active: They clean the room. Passive: The room is cleaned.

Practice MCQs

1. Passive of “She wrote the letter”:
A. The letter wrote her. B. The letter was written by her. C. The letter is writing.
Answer: B. Past simple passive = was/were + past participle.

2. Active of “The window was broken by Tom”:
A. Tom broke the window. B. Tom was broken by the window. C. The window broke Tom.
Answer: A. The active subject performs the action.

3. English ___ in many countries.
A. speaks B. is spoken C. is speaking
Answer: B. Present simple passive = is/are + past participle.

10. Auxiliary Verbs

Definition & Explanation

Auxiliary verbs are helping verbs used to make questions, negatives, tenses, and passive forms. Common auxiliaries are *be, do,* and *have*.

Examples

- She is studying.
- Do you like tea?
- They have finished.

Practice MCQs

1. ___ you understand the question?
A. Do B. Are C. Have
Answer: A. Use *do* with the present simple verb *understand*.

2. They ___ been waiting for an hour.
A. has B. have C. is
Answer: B. Use *have* with *they*.

3. She ___ not like coffee.
A. do B. does C. has
Answer: B. Use *does* with she/he/it.

3. Vocabulary

Word meanings, usage, combinations and synonyms

Vocabulary questions check word meanings and whether words are used and combined correctly.

1. Word Definitions

Definition & Explanation

You are given a definition and must choose the word that matches it. Focus on the main meaning of the definition.

Examples

- A person who buys goods or services is a customer.
- A person who teaches students is a teacher.

Practice MCQs

1. A person who teaches students is a ___.
A. doctor B. teacher C. driver
Answer: B. A teacher teaches students.

2. Something very important is ___.
A. essential B. ordinary C. distant
Answer: A. *Essential* means very important.

3. To make something better is to ___.
A. improve B. ignore C. remove
Answer: A. *Improve* means make better.

4. A place where books can be borrowed is a ___.
A. library B. factory C. stadium
Answer: A. A library holds books for reading or borrowing.

2. Word Usage

Definition & Explanation

Choose the word that fits the meaning and grammar of the sentence. Read the entire sentence and use the surrounding words as clues.

Examples

- Please make a decision.
- She gave me useful advice.

Practice MCQs

1. The manager will ___ a meeting tomorrow.
A. do B. hold C. take
Answer: B. The common phrase is *hold a meeting*.

2. Please ___ attention to the instructions.
A. pay B. give C. make
Answer: A. The phrase is *pay attention*.

3. He is interested ___ learning English.
A. on B. in C. at
Answer: B. The phrase is *interested in*.

4. The medicine had a positive ___ on her health.
A. affect B. effect C. effort
Answer: B. Here, *effect* is a noun meaning result.

3. Word Combination (Collocations)

Definition & Explanation

A word combination (collocation) is a pair or group of words that commonly go together in English.

Examples

- make a decision, heavy rain, strong coffee, take responsibility.

Practice MCQs

1. Choose the correct combination.
A. do a decision B. make a decision C. build a decision
Answer: B. We say *make a decision*.

2. Choose the correct combination.
A. heavy rain B. strong rain C. hard rainly
Answer: A. We say *heavy rain*.

3. Choose the correct combination.
A. pay attention B. make attention C. do attention
Answer: A. We say *pay attention*.

4. Choose the correct combination.
A. strong coffee B. hard coffee C. power coffeeing
Answer: A. We say *strong coffee*.

4. Word Making (Synonyms)

Definition & Explanation

A synonym is a word with the same or a similar meaning. Choose the word closest in meaning to the given word.

Examples

- Quick → fast; begin → start; silent → quiet.

Practice MCQs

1. Choose the synonym of “assist”.
A. help B. hide C. hurt
Answer: A. *Assist* means help.

2. Choose the synonym of “rapid”.
A. slow B. quick C. late
Answer: B. *Rapid* means quick.

3. Choose the synonym of “accurate”.
A. correct B. careless C. weak
Answer: A. *Accurate* means correct.

4. Choose the synonym of “purchase”.
A. sell B. buy C. borrow
Answer: B. *Purchase* means buy.

4. Reading

Sentence Comprehension • Text Cohesion • Opinion Matching • Long Text

Part 1 – Sentence Comprehension / Sentence Completion

Definition & Explanation

A sentence contains a missing word or blank. Choose the word that completes the sentence correctly in meaning and grammar. Read the full sentence before choosing.

Examples

- She was tired, so she went to bed early.
- Please switch off the lights before you leave.
- He studied hard and passed the exam.

Practice MCQs

1. The weather was cold, ___ we wore warm coats.
A. because B. so C. although
Answer: B. *So* introduces the result.

2. Could you ___ me your notebook for a day?
A. lend B. borrow C. owe
Answer: A. You *lend* something to another person.

3. The train arrived ___ than we expected.
A. early B. earlier C. earliest
Answer: B. Use a comparative with *than*.

4. She has lived here ___ 2020.
A. for B. since C. during
Answer: B. *Since* is used with a starting point.

5. Although it was raining, they ___ playing.
A. continued B. continue C. continuing
Answer: A. The past tense matches the sentence.

Part 2 – Text Cohesion (2 ordering tasks, 6 sentences each)

Text cohesion questions ask you to arrange sentences or identify how ideas connect. Look for pronouns, sequence words, contrast, and cause-and-effect clues. You receive 6 mixed-up sentences. The **first sentence is given**. You must put the other 5 sentences in the correct logical order.

Cohesion Clues to Look For

Clue type	What to look for
Pronouns	'he', 'she', 'it', 'they', 'this', 'these', 'the + noun' refer to something mentioned BEFORE.
Sequence markers	first / then / next / after that / subsequently / finally / in the end
Contrast markers	however / but / nevertheless / on the other hand / despite this
Result markers	therefore / as a result / consequently / because of this / so
Addition markers	moreover / furthermore / in addition / also / what is more
Time markers	at first / in the beginning / over time / eventually / nowadays
General → Specific	Texts often move from a broad statement to specific examples.
Problem → Solution	Look for a problem sentence followed by a solution sentence.

Practice Task 1 – Ordering

1	The role of social media in modern communication cannot be underestimated.
A	However, not everyone views this change positively.
B	Over time, platforms such as Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram attracted billions of users worldwide.
C	Despite these concerns, social media remains an integral part of daily life for most people.
D	What began as simple websites for sharing updates among friends quickly evolved into powerful tools for news, marketing, and political debate.
E	Critics argue that it has shortened attention spans, promoted misinformation, and contributed to rising levels of anxiety.

Answer & Explanation

Correct order: 1 → D → B → A → E → C
Logic: 1 (general claim) → D (what social media started as / how it grew) → B (global growth) → A (transition: not everyone agrees) → E (specific criticisms) → C (conclusion: despite issues, still important)

Practice Task 2 – Ordering

1	Volunteering can be one of the most rewarding experiences a person can have.
A	In addition to the personal benefits, volunteers also contribute to addressing important social issues.
B	As a result, many volunteers report feeling more confident, skilled, and connected to their communities after their experiences.
C	By giving their time and energy, volunteers help fill gaps in services that governments and businesses cannot always provide.
D	Furthermore, the sense of purpose and satisfaction that comes from helping others is difficult to find elsewhere.
E	Through volunteering, individuals gain practical experience, develop new skills, and form meaningful relationships with others.

Answer & Explanation

Correct order: 1 → E → B → D → A → C
Logic: 1 (general intro) → E (benefits for the individual) → B (result for the individual) → D (further personal benefit: sense of purpose) → A (transition to wider benefits) → C (benefits for society)

Practice Task 3 – Ordering (Study Time)

1	Many students find it difficult to manage their time during exam preparation.
A	As a result, they may feel stressed and struggle to revise every subject properly.
B	One useful solution is to prepare a realistic study timetable.
C	However, they often begin studying without deciding which topics are most important.
D	This plan helps them divide their available hours between different subjects.
E	They should also include short breaks so that they can stay focused.

Answer & Explanation

Correct order: 1 → C → A → B → D → E
Logic: “However” introduces the problem, “As a result” gives its consequence, “One useful solution” introduces the response, “This plan” refers to the timetable, and “also” adds another helpful recommendation.

Part 3 – Opinion Matching (4 opinions, 7 statements)

You read four short texts in which different people express their opinions on the same topic. Then you read 7 statements and decide which person’s text each statement matches. A person may be matched to more than one statement.

Strategy

- Read ALL four opinions before attempting ANY matching.
- Underline or note the KEY OPINION in each text — what does each person mainly believe?
- The statements are PARAPHRASES — they use different words than the original text.
- Look for similar IDEAS, not identical words.
- Some opinions may seem similar — look for subtle differences in viewpoint.
- If unsure, eliminate obviously wrong options first.

Practice Task – Topic: Fast Food

KAREN
I understand why fast food is popular — it's quick, cheap, and convenient for people with busy lives. However, I strongly believe that consuming it regularly is a serious health risk. The high levels of fat, salt, and sugar in most fast food products contribute directly to obesity, heart disease, and diabetes. Society needs to be better educated about these risks.

MARCUS
Fast food has become a scapegoat for all of society's health problems. The real issue is portion control and individual responsibility. If someone chooses to eat a burger every day, that is their choice. Governments should not interfere with personal dietary decisions. Education is useful, but ultimately, people are responsible for their own health.

PRIYA
What concerns me most about fast food is not the food itself but the industry behind it. The marketing of unhealthy products directly to children is deeply unethical. Children cannot make informed decisions about nutrition, yet they are bombarded with advertisements designed to create lifelong customers. This should be regulated far more strictly.

LEON
I work in the food industry and I've seen real changes in recent years. Many fast food chains are now offering healthier options — salads, grilled items, and lower-calorie meals. I think critics are too negative. The industry is responding to consumer demand and health concerns. It would be unfair to dismiss all fast food companies as irresponsible.

Statements – Match each to Karen (K), Marcus (M), Priya (P), or Leon (L):

1. The fast food sector is making genuine efforts to offer healthier products.
2. Repeated consumption of fast food poses a serious threat to people's health.
3. It is wrong that fast food companies target young consumers with advertising.
4. People should take personal responsibility for what they eat rather than blaming the industry.
5. Better public awareness of nutritional risks is needed.
6. The government should introduce tighter rules on how fast food is marketed to children.
7. The fast food sector is unfairly blamed for broader health issues in society.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Leon	Karen	Priya	Marcus	Karen	Priya	Marcus

Explanations: Leon says fast food chains are 'offering healthier options'. Karen talks about 'serious health risk' and 'better educated'. Priya focuses on 'marketing to children' and stricter regulation. Marcus says 'individual responsibility' and fast food is a 'scapegoat'.

Practice Example 2 – Learning Methods

Read the opinions and match each statement to the person who expresses that idea. Focus on meaning, even when the wording is different.

A — Mina
Online classes save travel time and allow students to replay lessons, but learners need a quiet place to study.

B — Omar
I prefer classroom lessons because I can ask questions immediately and work face-to-face with classmates.

C — Sara
A mixture of online and classroom learning is best because it offers flexibility and time with teachers in person.

Match each statement to A, B, or C.

1. This person prefers a combination of two learning methods.
2. This person values immediate discussion.
3. This person likes being able to replay a lesson.

Answers: 1 — C; 2 — B; 3 — A.

Part 4 – Long Text and Headings (7 paragraphs, 8 headings)

You read a long article of approximately 750 words divided into **7 paragraphs**. You are given **8 headings** — match 7 of them to the paragraphs. **One heading does not match.**

6-Step Strategy

Step	What to do
FIRST	Skim the whole text quickly to understand the general topic.
SECOND	Read the headings carefully — note key nouns, verbs, and concepts.
THIRD	For each paragraph, identify its MAIN IDEA (often the first or last sentence).
FOURTH	Match the main idea to the heading — they may use different vocabulary.
FIFTH	The extra heading often sounds relevant but doesn't quite fit any paragraph.
DO NOT	Base your answer on just one matching word — check the whole paragraph.

Practice Text – Artificial Intelligence in Education

Headings – Match paragraphs 1–7 to headings i–viii. One heading is NOT used.

	Heading
i	Concerns about fairness and access
ii	Personalised learning for individual students
iii	How AI is already being used in classrooms
iv	The history of technology in education
v	Preparing students for an AI-driven world
vi	The risk of reducing human connection in teaching
vii	Improving assessment and feedback
viii	Support for teachers, not replacement

Paragraph 1
Artificial intelligence is gradually making its presence felt in schools and universities across the world. From automated marking systems and intelligent tutoring programmes to virtual assistants and adaptive learning platforms, AI technologies are increasingly being integrated into the everyday experience of both students and educators. What was once the subject of science fiction is now a practical reality in many classrooms.

Paragraph 2
One of the most promising applications of AI in education is its ability to adapt to the individual needs of each learner. Unlike a single teacher managing thirty students, an AI system can simultaneously track the progress of every student, identify areas of weakness, and adjust the difficulty and content of exercises accordingly. This means that a student who struggles with fractions can receive additional support while a more advanced student is challenged with higher-level problems, all without disrupting the rest of the class.

Paragraph 3
Assessment is another area where AI is proving its value. Traditionally, teachers spend enormous amounts of time marking assignments, writing feedback, and recording results. AI tools can now perform these tasks in a fraction of the time, providing students with immediate, detailed feedback on their work. This not only reduces the administrative burden on teachers but also allows students to correct their mistakes quickly, which research suggests significantly improves retention and understanding.

Paragraph 4
Despite the excitement surrounding AI in education, some educators are cautious. They argue that teaching is fundamentally a human activity that depends on empathy, emotional intelligence, and the ability to read a room. A machine, however sophisticated, cannot replace the bond that forms between a teacher and a student, nor the motivational power of genuine human encouragement. If schools over-rely on AI, they risk producing students who are technically proficient but emotionally disconnected from learning.

Paragraph 5
There are also important questions to be asked about equity. Not all schools have equal access to technology, and not all students have reliable internet access at home. If wealthier schools can afford cutting-edge AI tools while underfunded schools cannot, the gap in educational outcomes between privileged and disadvantaged students may actually widen. Policymakers must ensure that the introduction of AI in education does not deepen existing inequalities.

Paragraph 6
Many proponents of AI in education are keen to emphasise that the goal is not to replace teachers but to empower them. By taking over time-consuming administrative tasks, AI can free teachers to focus on what they do best: inspiring students, facilitating discussion, and providing mentorship. In this view, AI serves as a powerful assistant rather than a competitor, allowing educators to dedicate more time and energy to the interpersonal aspects of their work.

Paragraph 7
Perhaps most importantly, AI literacy is fast becoming an essential skill for the modern workforce. Students who leave school without a basic understanding of how artificial intelligence works will be at a significant disadvantage in an increasingly automated job market. Schools therefore have a responsibility not only to use AI as a teaching tool but to teach about AI itself, ensuring that graduates are prepared to navigate and contribute to a world shaped by these technologies.

Para	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Heading	iii	ii	vii	vi	i	viii	v

Extra heading (NOT used): iv — ‘The history of technology in education’ is not discussed in any paragraph.

Practice Example 2 – Long Text Comprehension

Match each paragraph (1–7) with the best heading (A–H). One heading is extra and will not be used.

	Heading
A	Personalised learning with technology
B	Community action to protect nature
C	Making city travel more efficient
D	The value of regular physical activity
E	How the internet first developed
F	Simple ways to reduce household waste
G	Practising to learn a new language
H	Reading for enjoyment and well-being

Paragraph 1
Some schools use digital platforms that adjust tasks to a learner's progress. When a student finds an activity difficult, the programme may offer extra practice. When the student improves, it can provide more challenging work. This helps each learner move forward at a suitable pace.

Paragraph 2
Walking, swimming, and playing team sports strengthen the body. Physical activity can also lower stress and improve sleep. People do not always need an expensive gym membership; even a short walk each day can be a useful first step.

Paragraph 3
Families can reduce the amount of rubbish they produce by planning meals, reusing bags and containers, and choosing goods with less packaging. Sorting glass, paper, and plastic also helps recycling. These small actions work best when everyone in the household joins in.

Paragraph 4
Knowing vocabulary is important, but becoming confident in another language requires regular use. Learners should listen, speak, read, and write whenever they can. Reviewing phrases and learning from mistakes gradually helps them communicate more naturally.

Paragraph 5
In busy towns, growing numbers of cars can lead to traffic jams and unreliable journey times. Dedicated bus lanes, dependable train services, and clear travel information can help. For these options to attract more passengers, they also need to be affordable and convenient.

Paragraph 6
Stories and non-fiction books allow readers to discover new places, people, and ideas. Reading for pleasure can build vocabulary and imagination. It can also offer a quiet break from screens and the pressures of everyday life.

Paragraph 7
People in some neighbourhoods organise clean-ups, plant native trees, and report damage to local habitats. Working together makes these projects more successful and can encourage others to care for nearby rivers, parks, and wildlife.

Solution and explanation

Paragraph	Heading	Why
1	A	It describes digital tools that adapt learning to each student.
2	D	It explains the physical and mental benefits of exercise.
3	F	It gives examples of reducing household rubbish.
4	G	It explains that regular practice helps people learn a language.
5	C	It focuses on traffic problems and ways to improve city transport.
6	H	It explains the benefits of reading for enjoyment.
7	B	It describes community work to protect natural areas and wildlife.

Unused heading: E — None of the paragraphs describes the early development of the internet.

5. Writing Skills

4 parts • Models • Phrases • Practice tasks (50 minutes)

The Writing section includes four task types: **Word Level Writing, Short Text Writing, Three Written Responses to Questions,** and **Formal & Informal Writing**. You are assessed on task completion, grammar, vocabulary range, spelling, punctuation, register, and coherence.

1. Word Level Writing

Definition & Explanation

In this task, you take part in a club, course, or activity and receive a series of **five short text messages** from other members. You reply to each message briefly and appropriately. The focus is on understanding each message and giving a clear, relevant response. This is not an extended-writing task, so long paragraphs are not required.

How to answer

- Read each message carefully.
- Answer the point or question raised in that message.
- Keep each reply short, natural, and on topic.
- Check basic grammar, spelling, and punctuation.

Example

Club member: Hi! We are planning a photography club meeting on Saturday. Can you come?
Possible reply: Yes, I can come on Saturday. What time does the meeting start?

Practice Task 1 – Book Club

Imagine you have joined a book club. Write a short reply to each message.

1. Welcome to the club! What kind of books do you enjoy?
2. We are meeting at the library on Friday. Can you join us?
3. Could you suggest a book for our next discussion?
4. Please bring a notebook to the meeting. Is that okay?
5. We may change the meeting time. What time is best for you?

More Practice – Personal Questions

Write one short, natural response to each question, as if you were replying to a club member or another student.

1. What is your favourite hobby, and why do you enjoy it?
2. What is your favourite colour? Why do you like it?
3. What is your favourite flower, and what do you like about it?

Tip: Give a direct answer and, when useful, add one simple detail. For example: “My favourite hobby is reading because I enjoy learning new things.”

2. Short Text Writing

Definition & Explanation

In this task, you write a short text of around **20–30 words** in response to a situation or prompt. Your answer should stay on topic and communicate the required information clearly. Accurate grammar, punctuation, and spelling are important. Avoid adding unrelated details.

How to answer

- Identify exactly what the question asks you to do.
- Include the key information requested.
- Use complete, clear sentences.
- Keep close to the stated word limit and check your writing.

Example question

You have joined a fitness class. Write a short message to the instructor saying which class you want to attend and asking what you should bring. Write 20–30 words.

Sample answer (27 words)

Hello, I would like to join the evening fitness class on Tuesday. Could you please tell me what equipment or clothing I should bring? Thank you.

Practice questions

1. You are joining a college study group. Write a 20–30 word message introducing yourself and asking when the group meets.
2. You attended a workshop. Write a 20–30 word message thanking the organiser and mentioning one thing you learned.
3. Your friend invited you to a weekend activity, but you need more details. Write a 20–30 word reply asking about the time and place.

Quick reminder: Short does not mean incomplete: answer the prompt directly, include the necessary details, and avoid unnecessary sentences.

3. Three Written Responses to Questions

Definition & Explanation

In this task, you respond to **three questions**, often in the context of an online or social-network interaction. Each question asks for a relevant piece of information, an opinion, or a personal response. Read each question separately and make sure your answer addresses it.

How to answer

- Respond to all three questions.
- Stay focused on the question asked.
- Give a reason or example when it helps explain your answer.
- Use clear sentences and check grammar, spelling, and punctuation.

Example – Topic: A social networking group for students

Questions

1. What do you usually use social networking sites for?
2. Do you think online student groups are useful? Why?
3. What activity would you suggest for your group?

Sample responses

1. I mainly use social networking sites to keep in touch with friends and share useful study materials.
2. Yes, they are useful because students can ask questions, exchange notes, and remind one another about deadlines.
3. I would suggest a weekly online study session where members discuss difficult topics and help each other prepare for exams.

Practice questions – Topic: Learning English

1. Which English skill would you most like to improve, and why?
2. How do you practise English outside class?
3. What would make an English-learning group more helpful for students?

Before moving to the next task: Check that you have answered each question, kept your ideas relevant, and used clear, accurate English. The exact response length should follow the instructions given in your exam task.

4. Formal & Informal Writing (Emails)

	Formal Email	Informal Email
Word limit	120–150 words	40–50 words
Tone	Polite, professional and clear	Friendly, short and conversational
Contractions	Do **not** use contractions	Contractions are fine (can't, I'll)
Greeting	Dear Sir/Madam, / Dear Mr/Ms [surname],	Hi [name], / Hey [name]!
Closing	Yours faithfully / Yours sincerely	Take care, / Best wishes, / Cheers,

Linking Words and Discourse Markers

Function	Words and phrases
Adding information	moreover, furthermore, in addition, also, what is more, besides, not only…but also
Contrasting	however, nevertheless, despite this, on the other hand, although, even though, while, whereas, yet, in spite of this
Cause and reason	because, since, as, due to, owing to, on account of
Effect / result	therefore, as a result, consequently, thus, hence, for this reason, so
Giving examples	for example, for instance, such as, to illustrate, namely, in particular
Concession	although, though, even though, while, despite + noun/gerund, in spite of
Condition	if, unless, provided that, as long as, on condition that, given that
Sequence / order	first(ly), second(ly), then, next, after that, subsequently, finally, eventually, lastly
Emphasising	indeed, in fact, certainly, clearly, obviously, undoubtedly, above all
Summarising / concluding	in conclusion, to sum up, overall, in summary, on balance, to conclude, all in all
Time	when, while, as, before, after, since, until, as soon as, once, during, by the time
Purpose	in order to, so as to, so that, with the aim of

Formal Email Phrases – Complete Reference

Use	Phrases
Salutation	Dear Mr/Mrs/Ms [surname], | Dear Sir/Madam, | To Whom It May Concern,
Opening / purpose	I am writing to enquire about… | I am writing with reference to… | I am writing in response to your advertisement/letter/email regarding… | I am writing on behalf of [name/organisation]… | I am contacting you to request/express/complain/inform…
Giving background	As you may be aware,… | I would like to draw your attention to… | With reference to our recent conversation,… | I have recently become aware that…
Making requests	I would be grateful if you could… | Could you please provide… | I would appreciate it if you could… | I would like to request… | Would it be possible to…?
Expressing concern	I am concerned/worried that… | I am disappointed to hear that… | I wish to express my dissatisfaction with… | I feel that this situation is unacceptable.
Making suggestions	I would like to suggest that… | It may be worth considering… | I strongly recommend that… | Perhaps it would be beneficial to…
Apologising (if needed)	I sincerely apologise for any inconvenience caused. | I regret to inform you that… | I am sorry to hear that…
Closing statements	I look forward to hearing from you. | I await your response at your earliest convenience. | Please do not hesitate to contact me if you require further information. | I would appreciate a prompt response to this matter.
Sign-off	Yours faithfully, [full name] (when you used 'Dear Sir/Madam') | Yours sincerely, [full name] (when you used their name)

Informal Email Phrases

Use	Phrases
Salutation	Hi [name], | Hey [name]! | Dear [name],
Opening	How are you? | I hope you're well! | It was great to hear from you! | Guess what! | You won't believe this, but…
Body phrases	I just wanted to let you know that… | I thought you'd like to hear… | I can't believe that… | What do you think about…? | Have you heard that…?
Making suggestions	Why don't we…? | How about…? | We should definitely… | Let's…! | Maybe we could…?
Expressing feelings	I'm so excited about… | I was really surprised/shocked/disappointed that… | I can't wait to… | I'm not sure about…
Closing	Let me know what you think! | Write back soon! | Talk soon! | Hope to hear from you! | Can't wait to catch up!
Sign-off	Lots of love, | Take care, | Best wishes, | Cheers, | See you soon,

Solved Writing Example

Topic: You cannot attend an English class tomorrow. Write an email explaining why and asking for the lesson notes.

A. Formal Email

Subject: Request for Lesson Notes

Dear Sir/Madam,

I am writing to inform you that I will be unable to attend the English class tomorrow due to a personal commitment. I would be grateful if you could share the lesson notes or advise me on how I may catch up on the missed work.

Thank you for your time and understanding.

Yours faithfully,
[Your Name]

Why it is formal: It uses a professional greeting, polite request, complete sentences, and a formal closing.

B. Informal Email

Subject: Tomorrow's English Class

Hi Ayesha,

I can't make it to English class tomorrow because I have something personal to take care of. Could you please send me the notes after class? I'll catch up as soon as I can.

Thanks a lot!

Take care,
[Your Name]

Why it is informal: It uses a friendly greeting, everyday language, and a relaxed closing.

Quick checklist: Stay on topic, use the correct tone, check grammar and spelling, and include a suitable greeting and sign-off.

Best of luck for your exam! Practice material adapted from the APTIS General self-study booklet by Nasir Aziz, for personal and classroom study.